

**Redesigning Community Spaces for Sustainability, Accessibility, and Recreation: A  
Revitalization Plan for South Pointe**

Ruhani Jindal

CANConnect Micro-grants for Empowering Canadian Youth in Digital Civic Leadership and  
Service 2024 Project

March 31, 2025

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South Pointe is a beautiful neighbourhood that has many positive aspects. After living in this neighbourhood for over 12 years, I am beginning to find out ways that my neighbourhood can improve. My neighbourhood is not a healthy food neighborhood. There aren't nearly enough supermarkets or other locations where we can buy any kind of food. To make my neighborhood healthier, I wanted to add more places to get food closer to my house. The closest food places are over a few kilometers away. This distance isn't necessarily walkable if you want to quickly go buy something. In the initial stages of my project, I interviewed my mom about her views on our neighbourhood. I asked, "Do you think we live in a healthy food neighbourhood? Why/why not?" Her answer was, "No. The closest grocery store is 3km away from our neighbourhood. Our community is not a healthy food neighbourhood as it is not walkable." We also discussed how our area only has houses and schools. It doesn't have any food options or fun activities to do. (Areavibes). South Pointe is also full of seniors, and new families. This also makes it extremely important to add more things to the neighbourhood. Another problem is that the area overall only has houses of a specific price range which isn't affordable for everyone. That makes the socio-economic status of the children in the school quite similar to each other. This is why we also need cheaper options for apartments as the only condos in our area are on the more expensive side. I will also add a farmers' market with a CEA vertical farm to promote urban farming.

The first design feature I added is a huge building which will have two purposes. In the summers, I want to have a local farmers' market which can majorly help in making the neighbourhood closer to a healthy food neighbourhood. This farmers' market will have local produce which will help in reducing transportation of the food we eat, and it will support local farmers rather than imported food. The lights and energy for this building will come from the solar panels I have labeled on my map. I'm also planning to add a bit of a vertical farming area

that can help with fresh produce. Controlled Environment Agriculture (CEA) helps crops grow in the ideal conditions in terms of temperature, moisture control, and lack of unhealthy bugs and animals that eat the crops. (“Controlled Environment Agriculture (CEA) - Vertical Farming Academy”). I plan to incorporate this in the market somewhere where consumers can see it, as it raises awareness about what you eat if you can physically see it grow. In the winter, it is difficult to have a farmers’ market as Manitoban farmers can’t grow much in the winter. This is why I want this area to become a place where local businesses can be set up. Since the market will only be in the summer, this idea will be a nice activity and will be a different version of a mall. This “mall” will support local businesses, reduce transportation costs and climate change effects, and it will add something to do. Currently, if I want to go out with friends at any time, I always have to go to places on Pembina highway, 3km away, or areas in Bridgewater which is also 3km away. Overall, the walkability of my area isn’t great. “Walkability refers to the ability to safely walk to services and amenities within a reasonable distance, usually defined as a walk of 30 minutes or less” (Ionescu) This makes it difficult for us to walk there, and many kids our age can’t drive. The population in the schools for Grades 7-12 in our catchment is pretty high so many people must be experiencing this. All the bus routes also need 2 or more buses to cross a small area which means we normally need a parent to drive us to places. This has been a problem for many years which I aim to solve. I also want to have waste bins similar to the ones we have on campus. I like how they are labeled with pictures and words since it makes it easy to sort out our waste and save it from going into landfills. Waste minimization strategies are important for bigger buildings that have a lot of waste. (Waste Management at UWinnipeg | Sustainability | the University of Winnipeg).

The second design feature I added is a vegan café. This is also an attempt at adding a nice place for the residents of the area to relax, hang out with friends, study, or work. Many vegan places often fail because people judge the place for being vegan. This feature aims to show people that vegan places can also have good food and drinks. Since there aren't many cafes, bakeries, or coffee shops within walking distance, I feel this café can be successful despite being vegan. I feel the need for this place because as a lactovegetarian, I don't eat eggs. This makes it nearly impossible for me to ever find baked items that I can eat. In my family, we now bake a lot since we can't buy these things. Another reason why I want a vegan café is that according to a study, "Vegan diets result in 75% less climate-heating emissions, water pollution and land use than diets in which more than 100g of meat a day was eaten. Vegan diets also cut the destruction of wildlife by 66% and water use by 54%, the study found" (Carrington). We also learned about how vegan diets are better for the environment in class since they are a lot more sustainable. "Animal agriculture is responsible for 16.5% of all global greenhouse emissions" (Animal Aid). Even incorporating vegan foods into your lifestyle can be great for the environment. The café will also have a mini-library or bookstore to improve the aesthetic and make it a more comfortable environment for working. As I said before, there are many young families in our area and they could benefit from a library. We also moved here when I was young, which made it difficult for my mom to finish her studies after I was born because there were too many distractions at home. I aim to make a place where young mothers can continue their education after becoming mothers, get a break from their families, and have a relaxed and focused environment for them to achieve this.

The third design feature I added is a community center. This community center will include an outdoor skating rink that will be a basketball court in the summer. It will also have a

splash pad for children to play in. I aim to also have many senior and young children's recreational activities in this center. This center can also be rented out for private events or parties. The community center will have a few rooms that can be rented out to use the space well. The nearest community center in my area is St. Norbert Community Center, which is over 5km away. It also only has two rooms which isn't ideal. Community centers are important since they unite communities and provide support for community projects. (Sheerin). They also promote healthy living with classes and activities running. (Sheerin). I feel our community's residents don't know each other that well since we have no community activities which is why we need a community center in South Pointe.

The fourth design feature I added is a gym. This gym will have public features and private features. The two closest gyms to this area are Altea and Planet Fitness. Altea is more expensive and it's bigger. It can be intimidating to a person who is new to gyms. It is also 2 kilometers away. On the other hand, Planet Fitness is much more affordable, but it is 3 kilometers away. This gym will be much different than those gyms though. Firstly, it will have underground parking but will encourage its users to run or walk to the gym as the target audience is the residents of the area. Going to the gym can benefit your mental health, and physical health, and can provide a sense of personal achievement which makes this even more important. ("5 Reasons You Should Start Going to the Gym Today"). This gym will also have rehabilitation facilities for seniors who may have recently suffered from heart attacks or who in general, should have more exercise. I wanted to do this because I have seen my grandmother's health deteriorate from lack of exercise since she cannot go on outdoor walks, and she doesn't have much to do here. Every time she goes to the doctor, they always tell her to begin walking and exercising more with activities such as yoga or some basic stretches. This gym will have areas specifically

designed for people like her who have difficulty walking for longer periods. I will also include many free features like a walking track since I believe that in a cold city like Winnipeg, going on daily walks is equally important in the winter as it is in the summer. “Walking daily can help with increased cardiovascular and pulmonary (heart and lung) fitness, reduced risk of heart disease and stroke, improved management of conditions such as hypertension (high blood pressure), high cholesterol, joint and muscular pain or stiffness, and diabetes, stronger bones, and improved balance” (Department of Health & Human Services). Also, it will include the normal gym machines and workout areas along with being specialized with massages and spas. I will also include different levels of memberships so there is something for everyone.

The fifth feature I have included is a public park. The park we have nearby is quite small and only focused on little kids. This park will be built more equitably and will include basic exercise machines for seniors. This is like parks in India which are usually more focused on seniors than kids. These are called open gymnasiums and are often located in parks. (Bari). Open gymnasiums can be very motivating with the fresh air instead of a stuffy gym. They can especially be good for seniors since they are often judged in regular gyms. This is also why I made the gym have rehabilitation physical therapy areas. The park will also have a playground for kids, and a multi-use field for sports like soccer, cricket, baseball, etc. I also will include shaded benches and seating areas which often help with the social involvement of seniors as after their morning walks, they can meet up with their friends here. I was also inspired by Central Park as it will be quite big. I will also add a forest since trees are good for the environment. This forest will have many types of native tree species often found in the Prairies. In North America, Urban heat islands are huge problems. “Urban heat islands occur when cities replace land cover such as forest, open water and greenery with buildings, pavement and other materials that absorb and

retain heat” (Sharma). This is why I felt it is important to include more green space in the area I’m designing. Currently, the area has soil everywhere, but it has no greenery. I feel this is a waste of space that can have so much greenspace like what I’m suggesting with this park.

The sixth design feature I added is affordable condos. “In 2016, the COH’s most conservative estimate suggested at least 235,000 people experience homelessness in the country each year” (Simone). The Canadian Observatory of Homelessness is an organization that researched the unhoused in Canada. This estimate is the closest we will get to the real numbers if we are thinking of statistics related to homelessness. But 235,000 people is a lot of people considering that Canada is a place with a “high standard of living, well-developed infrastructure, advanced healthcare and education systems, and a strong economy” (Krishnaraj). One of these buildings will be a senior home and the other will be more affordable housing to increase the socio-economic diversity of the area. A big problem of our area is that it only has houses of a specific price range which isn’t affordable for everyone. That makes the socio-economic status of the children in the school quite similar to each other. I feel we should have diversity in schools and the lack of price ranges doesn’t help with that. More diversity in schools also helps increase awareness for children. “Diversity in schools exposes students to various cultural and social groups, preparing students to become better citizens in their communities” (“The Importance of Multicultural Education - School of Education”). This is why we also need cheaper options for apartments as the only condos in our area are on the more expensive side. These apartments will both have underground parking to save up space, big bike stands to support biking and more sustainable forms of transportation. This area already had a community garden which I plan to extend since people in this high-density housing may also have an interest in gardening.



This whole area will be powered by the solar panels I labeled on the map. “Our personal vehicles are a major cause of global warming” (“Car Emissions and Global Warming”). This is why there will also be rental bikes and low-speed vehicles, also known as LSVs. These will promote having more fresh air as air conditioning/heating also isn’t great for the environment. This will be because I don’t want too many roads in this area. This one road I added in the middle is just so there is a connection between Kenaston and Waverley since currently, we need to drive around the whole neighbourhood to cross there. I also wish to have more bus routes specifically for this area since there are a lot of apartments and housing here for people who may not be able to drive or may not be able to afford cars. There will be bus stops specifically in front of the apartments and condos to make it easier for residents. I feel this bus route will be particularly valuable because it is a new area that doesn’t have a close by bus route. (Budwiski). The reason why I picked this area is because it has been empty since I moved here in 2011. It also doesn’t have grass or any greenery which I feel makes it a use of space. Also, there is a major need for a connection between Kenaston and Waverley since Lee Boulevard randomly ends when it goes closer to Kenaston which I honestly do not understand the reasoning for. Another issue is that Lee Boulevard is a gravel road and the houses on it have problems with their water supply which is weird since they are so close to a neighbourhood with a great supply of it. I hope these apartments’ water supply can be connected to these houses. Overall, the area is focused on helping the residents of the neighbourhood. All the buildings I have mentioned will have green roofs and vines on the walls especially the apartments.

In summary, South Pointe is a beautiful neighborhood with many positive aspects, and is struggling with a lack of healthy food options and affordable housing options. The closest grocery store is over a kilometer away, making it difficult for residents to walk to buy food. The

area is predominantly composed of houses and schools, which contribute to the socio-economic disparity among children in these schools. To improve the situation, I plan to add more food options and activities, such as a farmers' market and a CEA vertical farm. The area will be powered by solar panels and will feature rental bikes and low-speed vehicles (LSVs) to reduce traffic. I also plan to increase bus routes and make a connection between Kenaston and Waverley, as well as more greenery and green roofs on buildings. The area is aimed at helping residents and promoting urban farming. In conclusion, my design will greatly improve my neighbourhood, South Pointe, and will help current and future residents greatly. It will improve the area by promoting sustainable transportation, adding greenery, and making new places for the community that are not houses or schools. It will also support local small businesses and farmers and raise awareness about the need for features like these.

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# LEGEND - Rethinking South Pointe

Trees



Houses



Greenery  
-Grassy, Garden Plants



Apartments



Underground  
Parking



Walk/Bike  
Paths



Bicycle  
Stands



Community  
Garden



Solar Power  
Lamps



Solar Panels



Roads for  
Vehicles



Playground



Field



① Farmer's Market/  
Local Food Market

② Vegan Cafe

③ Community Center +  
Skating Rink + Splash Pad

④ Gym/Walking Track  
Private Public

⑤ Public Park  
(Similar to central park)

⑥ Residential Areas  
For Seniors and Families

Areas I  
can't change

\* All buildings have green  
roofs, gardens, or patios  
on the roofs





### 3. Letter to the City Councillor

January 9th, 2025

Dear Councillor Janice Lukes,

I am Ruhani Jindal, a grade 12 student from the University of Winnipeg Collegiate, and a recipient of the Glocal Foundation of Canada's microgrant program.

(<https://glocalfoundation.ca/microgrants>) I have read on your website that the redevelopment of École St. Avila's school ground was recognized by Staples Canada as one of Canada's top 10 Environmentally Responsible School Grounds under your leadership. I found this inspiring and want to suggest another sustainable development for an area in your constituency close to my home. The area I have ideas for, is the vacant area between Lee Boulevard, Kenaston Boulevard, and Waverley Street. I have been living in South Pointe for 12 years now and have realized that there are some more amenities that area residents can use. These include but are not limited to additional greenspace, affordability, and facilities for active living, as well as suitable housing to cater to specific demographics of this neighborhood. I also was thinking of places to go for the youth as they are a part of more than 50% homes in this neighborhood. Keeping all these residents' needs in mind, I have envisioned an idea to develop the place and want to share that with you. I have attached a copy of my map along with this letter.

The most prominent part of the plan is its wholesomeness. My plan has everything a family could need, an affordable house surrounded by parks and trails, a healthy food market, active life centres, and community spaces providing equitable access to the young and old. Our South Pointe neighbourhood is already densely populated, but at the same time, it is a neighbourhood of choice for many young families. 31% of the population of South Pointe consists of minors which shows how this neighborhood attracts young families and therefore needs affordable housing. As per the City of Winnipeg 2021 census, more than 75% of the residents in our area are visible minorities, due to which we see many multi-generational families living together. Overall, the composition of the population in our neighborhood has a wide range of ages that creates the need of activities for all age groups. Currently, I feel the price range of housing in the neighborhood does not demonstrate equitable building. My plan creates residential space that is affordable, and thus promotes building equitably. The residential space connects the residents to the newly built public schools in the area. At the same time, the plan provides a residential complex for seniors too, as that is going to be a growing need in the near

future. As I mentioned earlier, there are many seniors living in the area with their multi-generational families, it can be reasonably expected that there is a need for an independent living space for seniors that also provides access to facilities like senior recreational centres, an open gymnasium, and community centres which I have included in my plan.

The other vital characteristics of my plan are its greenspace and energy-efficient technology which are based on sustainable development ideologies. I find that these two features are an important part of any socially responsible plan as well as a measure to sustain the densely populated neighbourhood. There is a park suitable for all age groups surrounded by the native trees of the Prairies, and buildings with green roofs and solar panels. Green roofs are energy saving and also control moisture in buildings. These roofs add beauty as well as fresh air to the area while solar panels can reduce the use of energy to a great extent. Therefore, it is important to have that provision incorporated in the basic design of the new development.

I have noted that you have announced new developments for Waverley and Richmond sites under the “re-envisioning exercise” in 2023. I appreciate your passion for all the great developments in your constituency and wanted to bring to your attention, and I hope you can consider this great space that can be developed to cater to the needs of the growing population of this neighbourhood.

Thank you for considering my ideas and taking the time to do so.

Sincerely,

Ruhani Jindal



# Meeting Request: Proposal for South Pointe Revitalization Project

External



Inbox x



**Ruhani Jindal** <ruhanijindal@gmail.com>

to jlukes, me ▼

Thu 9 Jan, 21:39



Dear Councillor Lukes,

I hope this email finds you well. My name is Ruhani Jindal, and I am a Grade 12 student at the University of Winnipeg Collegiate. I recently received a \$1,000 microgrant from the GLOCAL Foundation for my project, *Redesigning Community Spaces for Sustainability, Accessibility, and Recreation: A Revitalization Plan for South Pointe*.

This initiative aims to address key challenges in our neighborhood, including access to healthy food, community inclusivity, and sustainability. By introducing a year-round farmers' market incorporating Controlled Environment Agriculture (CEA), affordable housing options, and a multi-use public park, the project focuses on fostering economic growth and environmental consciousness while creating an inclusive community space.

I have attached a letter and a conceptual map of the project for your review. I would greatly appreciate the opportunity to meet with you to discuss the project further, share my ideas, and inquire about city regulations or resources that could support these efforts. Your insights as our city councillor would be invaluable in ensuring the success of this initiative.

Please let me know if you would be available to meet at your earliest convenience. I am flexible with scheduling and can accommodate a time that works best for you.

Thank you for your time and for your continued commitment to our community. I look forward to the possibility of collaborating with you on this project.

Warm regards,  
Ruhani Jindal

204-952-3716

## FW: Meeting Request: Proposal for South Pointe Revitalization Project

Inbox x



→ Chow, Andrea - Office of Councillor Janice Lukes - Deputy Mayor City of Winnipeg <achow@winnipeg.ca>

Tue, Jan 14, 12:00 PM ☆ 😊 ↶ ⋮

to me, ruhani.j@glocalfoundation.ca, Janice ▾

Dear Ruhani,

Thank you for reaching out and for sharing your exciting **project**, *Redesigning Community Spaces for Sustainability, Accessibility, and Recreation*. Congratulations on receiving the \$1,000 microgrant from the GLOCAL Foundation—it's truly inspiring to see young leaders like you taking initiative to improve our community.

Unfortunately, Councillor Lukes is unable to meet with you at this time as the 2025 city budget is being prepared and the process is very time consuming. However, we greatly appreciate the work you are doing, and we want to support your efforts in other ways. Here is some information that may be helpful for your **project**:

- The City of Winnipeg is not a land developer – typically what happens is that land is sold to a developer who then works with city planners to plan and approve the area. In the area that you are looking at, that land was owned by the Province of Manitoba and was sold to Qualico. Qualico is a large land developer and is in the process of building the Bison Run neighbourhood. Here is the master plan for Bison Run <https://janicelukes.ca/wp-content/uploads/2024/10/Bison-Run-Phase-4-report.pdf>
- There will be many types of housing offered in Bison Run including single family homes, condominiums, multi-family homes including some rentals. Housing prices are driven by market demand and by the builders. It is possible that some of the multi-family rentals may have some affordable units in them. These typically go for 10% less than the market rate – this has not yet been determined. We acknowledge that there is a need for more affordable housing solutions in the area and are working with the Federal government on grant programs to make it enticing for developers to include in their plans.
- Many of the suggestions you made have been included in the planning of the **South** Winnipeg Recreational Centre, which is a city **project**. Phase 1 will include an indoor walking track, multiple gyms, several multi-purpose rooms that can be rented out for activities and social gatherings, a daycare and an outdoor splash pad. Future phases could include a pool, indoor ice facilities, library and outdoor sports courts. For more information, please see this link <https://janicelukes.ca/blog/update-south-winnipeg-recreation-campus/>
- Developers are also responsible for putting in active transportation pathways for walking and biking, playgrounds and parks – you will see these go in over the next couple of years as well as two shade structures.
- A fire/paramedic station, also a city **project** is being built and is expected to open in late 2026. In the meantime a temporary station just opened in Prairie **Pointe** to service the area until the Bison Run station opens – see here <https://janicelukes.ca/your-neighbourhood/whyte-ridge/waverley-west-fire-paramedic-station-15/>
- As you point out, our aging population will require new facilities to house those who can no longer live on their own. Although there is no room for one to be built in Bison Run, there is one being planned in nearby Bridgwater Trails. They have secured land on Bridge Lake Drive and plan to build both an Assisted Living and Personal Care Home. They are still waiting on Provincial approval in order to proceed. Here is a link to the **project** being done by Mennonite Central Committee <https://lindenwood.ca/bridgwater>
- Councillor Lukes is very supportive of community gardens and has assisted with the costs of setting up two in the area. I believe that the Bison Run garden will only be open for one more year and then that land will be developed by the owner Qualico who have graciously allowed the use of the land for the last few years. The second garden is located nearby on Cadboro Rd. See here for more information: <https://janicelukes.ca/blog/cadboro-community-garden> & <https://janicelukes.ca/blog/bison-run-community-garden/>
- We are very lucky to have the largest and most successful Farmer's Market nearby in St Norbert. These operations are typically seasonal and operate on weekends – making it a challenge to be financially successful throughout the year to pay for land and building costs. Here is a link to their website: <https://stnorbertyfarmersmarket.ca/>

Thank you for sharing your innovative vision for the development of the area. Your **project** aligns with many of the initiatives that are currently underway and that are essential to fostering a vibrant neighborhood.

If you have specific questions, please feel free to contact me directly. We are happy to help where we can.

**Andrea Chow**

Community Relations

Office of Deputy Mayor Janice Lukes

Councillor for Waverley West Ward





**GLOCAL**  
FOUNDATION OF CANADA

**REVITALIZING  
SOUTH POINTE:  
SUSTAINABLE,  
INCLUSIVE, AND  
ACCESSIBLE SPACES**



## SPECIAL FEATURES

- ✓ Affordable Housing
- ✓ A Vegan Cafe
- ✓ A Gym
- ✓ An Inclusive Park
- ✓ CEA Technology
- ✓ And a lot of fun!

# A Proposal to Improve a Community Near You!

**Ruhani Jindal**